

How to Build Your Moving Company Rate Card (The Operator's Pricing Workbook)

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You already know what competitors charge. The Pricing Guide 2026 covers market rates by move type and city size.

This is the operational guide — how to calculate your actual cost per job, structure every fee on a customer's bill, and build a rate card that protects your margins on every move type, every time.

Step 1: Calculate Your True Hourly Cost

Most operators set rates by looking at competitors. That tells you what the market will bear — but not whether you'll make money at that rate.

Here's how to calculate your real hourly cost for a 2-person crew with one truck:

Monthly Fixed Costs

Cost Item	Monthly
Truck payment or depreciation reserve	\$600 – \$1,500
Commercial auto insurance	\$300 – \$700
Cargo liability insurance	\$100 – \$300
General liability insurance	\$150 – \$400
Workers' comp (if applicable)	\$200 – \$600
Truck maintenance reserve	\$400 – \$800
Overhead (software, phone, admin)	\$200 – \$500
Total fixed monthly cost	\$1,950 – \$4,800

Variable Costs Per Job

Cost Item	Per Job
Fuel (average 30-mile round trip)	\$18 – \$28
Crew labor (2 movers × \$19/hr × 4 hours)	\$152
Supplies (tape, wrap, floor runners)	\$20 – \$50
Total variable cost per 4-hour job	\$190 – \$230

Hourly Cost Calculation

Monthly fixed costs ÷ Monthly billable hours + Variable cost per hour = Your true hourly cost

Example:

- Monthly fixed: \$3,200
- Monthly billable hours (20 jobs × 4 hours): 80 hours
- Fixed cost per hour: \$40
- Variable cost per hour (labor + fuel + supplies): \$52
- **True hourly cost: \$92**

At \$130/hour, your gross margin is \$38/hour — about 29%. Healthy.

At \$95/hour, your gross margin is \$3/hour — catastrophically thin.

Run this calculation with your real numbers before you publish any rate.

Step 2: Define Your Rate Structure

Choose Your Billing Model

Hourly with minimum:

- Transparent for customers
- You're protected if the job runs long
- Risk: customer tries to rush the move to reduce hours (creates damage claims)
- Best for: local moves under 3 hours, apartment moves, small residential

Flat rate:

- Customers prefer it for planning certainty
- Your risk if you underestimate the job
- Requires accurate pre-move inventory or walkthrough
- Best for: larger local moves, long-distance, commercial moves

Hourly with cap:

- Hybrid that combines protection (hourly billing) with customer certainty (cap)
- Example: "\$145/hour, 3-hour minimum, capped at \$700 for this job"
- Best for: medium-sized local moves where time is uncertain

Most operators offer all three depending on the job. Have the conversation with each customer and let them choose.

Set Your Base Hourly Rate

Using your hourly cost calculation:

Your floor rate = True hourly cost ÷ (1 - target margin %)

Example:

- True hourly cost: \$92

- Target gross margin: 35%
- Floor rate: $\$92 \div 0.65 = \textbf{\$141.50/hour}$

Check this against your market research. If market rates are \$130/hour and your floor is \$141.50, you either need to reduce costs or accept lower margins initially while you build the reviews that justify a premium.

Set Your Minimum Charge

Define the minimum regardless of actual job time:

Recommended:

- 2-hour minimum for small local moves
- 3-hour minimum for standard residential moves
- 4-hour minimum for larger homes

Why minimums matter: A 45-minute job still requires travel time, loading/unloading, and crew time. Without a minimum, small jobs destroy your hourly yield.

Step 3: Build Your Complete Fee Schedule

Travel Fee

Every job involves driving to and from the origin. Define your travel policy clearly:

Option A: Portal-to-portal billing

The clock starts when the truck leaves your warehouse and stops when it returns. Customers pay all drive time. Simple to explain and implement.

Option B: Job-to-job billing + travel fee

Clock runs only during the actual move. Charge a flat travel fee (\$40 to \$100) to cover the drive to and from the job. More customer-friendly.

Option C: Fuel surcharge

Charge a flat fuel fee per job (\$25 to \$75) regardless of distance within your service area. Transparent and easy.

Most operators use Option B or C. Define your policy and state it explicitly in every quote.

Specialty Item Fees

Item	Fee Range
Upright piano	\$150 – \$350
Grand piano	\$350 – \$750
Gun safe / large safe (400+ lbs)	\$175 – \$450
Pool table (disassembly + reassembly)	\$250 – \$600
Hot tub	\$250 – \$500
Motorcycle	\$100 – \$250
Antique or oversized furniture	Custom quote
Exercise equipment (treadmill, Peloton, etc.)	\$75 – \$150

These fees must be communicated at booking — not discovered at the job site. Build a checklist into your quote process: "Do you have any of the following items?"

A piano that takes 45 additional minutes and requires 3 people instead of 2 costs you \$57 in extra labor (1 extra person × \$19/hr × 45 min). If you don't charge for it, that \$57 comes out of your margin on that job — plus the liability exposure if something goes wrong with a specialty item.

Stair and Access Fees

Situation	Fee
Stairs per flight (beyond first)	\$50 – \$100 per flight
Long carry (beyond 75 feet from truck)	\$50 – \$150
Elevator buildings	No extra charge (typically)
No parking / significant walk from truck	\$50 – \$150
Narrow staircase (extra time/risk)	\$50 – \$100 extra

State these in your booking confirmation. A customer who knew about the stair fee won't dispute it. One who finds out at invoice time will leave a bad review.

Packing Service Fees

If you offer packing:

Service	Fee
Full packing labor (per packer, per hour)	\$50 – \$85/hr/packer
Packing materials (boxes, tape, paper)	Cost × 1.4 to 1.6 markup
Unpacking service	Same as packing labor rate

Packing is your highest-margin service. Customers who need packing done professionally are less price-sensitive than customers who just need transport. Build it into your service offering explicitly and quote it on every call.

Cancellation and Rescheduling

Define your policy before you need it:

Situation	Fee
Cancellation 48+ hours out	No fee
Cancellation 24 to 48 hours out	25 to 50% of minimum charge
Cancellation same day / no-show	50 to 100% of minimum charge
Rescheduling 24+ hours out	No fee
Rescheduling less than 24 hours	\$50 – \$100 administrative fee

Moving no-shows are a real cost. A crew that shows up to a job that's been cancelled without notice loses a morning of earnings. The cancellation fee doesn't fully compensate — but it changes customer behavior and reduces the frequency.

Step 4: Build Your Quote Template

Every quote should include:

1. **Job details:** Origin and destination addresses, move date, crew size, truck size
2. **Estimated time:** Based on your inventory assessment
3. **Base charge:** Hourly rate × estimated hours or flat-rate quote
4. **Itemized extras:** Any specialty fees, stair fees, packing

5. **Travel fee:** Your standard travel policy
6. **Total estimated cost + possible range:** "Estimated \$580 to \$720 based on 4 to 5 hours"
7. **What's included:** Blankets, dollies, shrink wrap
8. **What's NOT included:** Disassembly of complex furniture (or is it?), packing (or is it?), specialty items
9. **Cancellation policy:** In writing

A detailed quote prevents disputes. Customers who agreed to a specific scope at a specific rate rarely dispute the final invoice.

Step 5: Annual Pricing Review

Set a calendar reminder every 6 months to review:

- Have labor costs changed? (Minimum wage increases, market wages)
- Has fuel price moved significantly?
- Has insurance renewed at a different rate?
- Have your competitors raised their rates?
- Is your gross margin holding above target?

Operators who set prices at launch and never revisit them quietly watch their margins erode as costs rise. A 10% cost increase over two years with no pricing adjustment is a real reduction in profitability.

Want help building a rate card that's competitive in your specific market? Book a free strategy call and we'll walk through what other operators are charging in your area.